

Stop The Rollercoaster

Why anxious and fearful avoidant partners are magnetically drawn to each other, and how to stop the cycle that's breaking you both.

8

SECTIONS TO READ

3

EXERCISES TO DO

1

COMMITMENT TO MAKE

The Anxious + Fearful Avoidant pairing is the most *intense and confusing* combination in all of attachment science. You feel everything deeply. They feel everything deeply. And yet the connection keeps slipping away. This guide breaks down exactly why, and what you can actually do about it.

1 Who Is the FA?

2 Who Are You?

3 The Magnetic Pull

4 The Push-Pull Cycle

5 What the FA Actually Needs

6 What You Must Stop

7 Communication Scripts

8 When It Works vs. When to Go

Who Is the Fearful Avoidant (FA)?

Also called Disorganized Attachment, the most complex style of all



THE SCIENCE

Fearful Avoidant (FA) attachment develops when the people who raised you were both the source of love AND the source of fear. Your body learned: "I need you, but you scare me." That contradiction never got resolved, and it still runs in the background today.

Main & Hesse (1990): Disorganized Attachment Theory; Liotti (1992): Internal Working Models

THE FA'S CORE WOUND



THE FA'S INNER CONFLICT

"I need you and I'm terrified of you at the same time. When you get close, I panic. When you pull away, I panic. There is no safe position. My nervous system learned that love and danger are the same thing."

FEAR OF ABANDONMENT

- Terrified of rejection & being left
- Constantly watches for any sign you might leave
- Can become clingy or desperate in moments
- May push you away before you get the chance to leave first

FEAR OF INTIMACY

- Getting close sets off a panic alarm inside them
- Pulls back when things start feeling really good
- Often goes cold right after a really connected moment
- Opening up feels dangerous to them, not safe

FA TRAITS AT A GLANCE



Hot & Cold behavior



Unpredictable mood shifts



Shuts down when close



Chronic self-sabotage



Cycles of approach & retreat



Dismisses own needs



Deeply empathetic inside



Capable of healing w/ safety



NEUROSCIENCE

The FA's brain alarm goes off in two opposite situations: when they're alone (terrifying) AND when someone gets too close (also terrifying). There is almost no emotional setting that feels completely safe to them. The range of comfort is extremely narrow.

Coan & Sbarra (2015): Emotion regulation in attachment; Porges (2011): Polyvagal Theory

Who Are You in This Dynamic?

Why you're more activated here than in any other pairing



THE SCIENCE

Anxious attachment forms when the people who raised you were sometimes warm and sometimes cold or checked out. Your brain learned: "Love isn't guaranteed. I have to watch closely and work hard to keep it." So now your body is always on high alert for any sign the relationship might be in trouble.

Bowlby (1969, 1973): Attachment Theory; Mikulincer & Shaver (2016): Attachment in Adulthood



YOUR INNER WORLD

"When they pull away, my entire nervous system goes into emergency mode. I need to fix it, reach out, check in, because the silence feels like the relationship is ending."

ANXIOUS BEHAVIORS THAT ESCALATE IN THIS DYNAMIC

ALWAYS ON ALERT

You read every text, every tone of voice, and every little behavior for signs they're pulling away. Your body is always scanning for danger.

PROTEST BEHAVIORS

Double-texting, calling, checking their activity. Your body does these things automatically when it feels the connection slipping away, even if your brain knows better.

SELF-BLAME

"What did I do wrong?" becomes your first thought whenever the FA pulls away, even though their distance is almost never about you specifically.

WHY THIS PAIRING AMPLIFIES ANXIOUS SYMPTOMS

THE INTERMITTENT REINFORCEMENT EFFECT

- Most relationships have *some* inconsistency. The FA has a *built-in hot-and-cold cycle*. This keeps your nervous system on full alert all the time.
- The moments they **DO** show up feel incredibly good. Your brain releases a rush because the reward was unpredictable, like a slot machine that hits big sometimes.
- This creates an addiction-like loop: more distance = more craving = harder to walk away.



BEHAVIORAL PSYCHOLOGY

Scientists call this "variable reinforcement", the exact same thing that makes gambling addictive. When a reward is unpredictable, your brain actually grabs on harder. When the FA shows up sometimes but not others, your brain gets more hooked than if they showed up every single time.

Skinner (1957): Schedules of Reinforcement; Fisher et al. (2005): Love & Dopamine fMRI Studies



THIS IS NOT A CHARACTER FLAW

Your intense reactions in this relationship are your nervous system doing exactly what it was trained to do. It is not a character flaw. Healing is about teaching your body new patterns, not beating yourself up for the old ones.

Why You're Magnetically Drawn to Each Other

It's not random. Your nervous systems are speaking the same early language.

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THE NERVOUS SYSTEM CONNECTION

Both anxious and fearful avoidant people feel love more intensely than most. You both have big emotional experiences. This creates an instant feeling of "finally, someone who FEELS things like I do." That depth feels like a soul connection. But it is also a wound connection, two people recognizing the same old pain in each other.

WHY YOU FEEL IRRESISTIBLY COMPATIBLE

WHAT YOU BRING

- Unwavering pursuit: the FA's abandonment fear is temporarily soothed
- Emotional intensity that mirrors the FA's inner world
- Unconditional presence: the FA never has to chase
- Warmth that the FA craves but can't generate for themselves

THE FA BRINGS

- Mystery and unpredictability that you interpret as "depth"
- Emotional unavailability that triggers your chase response
- Moments of profound closeness that feel worth fighting for
- High-intensity connection that feels like passion



ATTACHMENT NEUROSCIENCE

Both FA and anxious people feel emotional bonds more intensely than average. Their brains produce stronger stress and bonding signals in relationships. That electric "I've never felt this before" feeling at the start is completely real. It is not just in your head, it is happening in your body.

Carter et al. (2017): Oxytocin & Social Bonding; Levine & Heller (2010): Attached

THE FAMILIAR WOUND RECOGNITION

"I'VE KNOWN YOU BEFORE"

- Both anxious partner and FA grew up with emotionally inconsistent caregivers. On a subconscious level, this pairing feels like home.
- The FA's hot-and-cold mirrors what you experienced in childhood: *love that you had to work for.*
- Your persistence mirrors what the FA needed as a child: *someone who wouldn't give up on them.*
- Researchers call these early patterns "internal working models", basically your brain's blueprint for what love is supposed to look like. They pull you toward what feels familiar, even when it is not good for you.



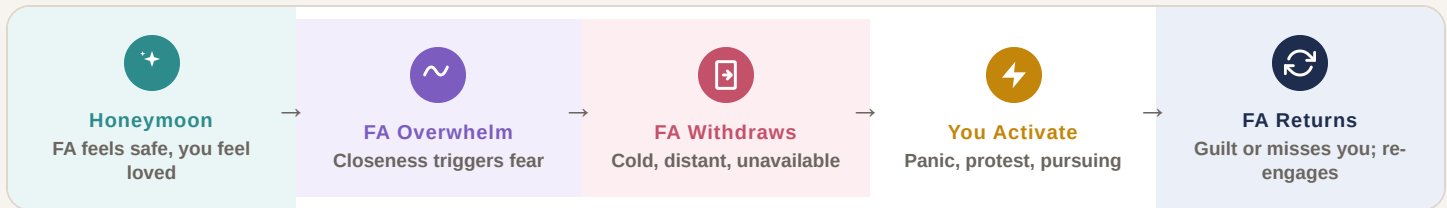
THE TRUTH

The intensity you feel with an FA is *real*. It's not imaginary. But intensity ≠ compatibility. Understanding this is the first step toward choosing intentionally.

The Push-Pull Cycle

Understanding the loop that keeps you both stuck

THE FULL CYCLE: HOW IT ALWAYS GOES



WHAT THE FA THINKS (EACH STAGE)

- Honeymoon: "This is amazing, I feel safe"
- Overwhelm: "This is too much, I'm suffocating"
- Withdrawal: "I need space to feel like myself"
- You pursue: "See? Everyone smothers me"
- Returns: "I miss them. Maybe I overreacted."

WHAT YOU THINK (EACH STAGE)

- Honeymoon: "I finally found someone who gets me"
- Overwhelm: "Something changed. What did I do?"
- Withdrawal: "They're leaving. I need to fix this NOW."
- You pursue: "I'll reach out one more time..."
- Returns: "I knew they loved me. See, it worked."



RELATIONSHIP SCIENCE

Researchers call this the "Anxious-Avoidant Trap" or the "Pursue-Withdraw Pattern." It is the most common and destructive relationship cycle, because both people's nervous systems are fired up at the same time, each person's reaction making the other's worse.

Johnson (2008): Emotionally Focused Therapy; Gottman (1994): What Predicts Divorce



WHY NEITHER PERSON CAN SEE IT IN THE MOMENT

When your body is in panic mode, the thinking part of your brain goes offline. Neither you nor the FA can think clearly or see the big picture in the middle of the cycle. That is why the same fight keeps happening over and over. It is not that you are not trying hard enough. It is biology.

What the FA Actually Needs (vs. What They Say)

The translation guide to understanding your partner's real signals



THE FA'S PARADOX

Fearful avoidants deeply *want* connection and *push away* the very thing they want. They may say "I need space" when what they really mean is "I'm scared and I don't know how to say that." Learning to hear what they actually mean is one of the most powerful things you can do.

THE FA TRANSLATION GUIDE

WHAT THEY SAY VS. WHAT THEY MEAN

WHAT THEY SAY

"I need space."
"You're too much."
"I don't want a relationship."
"I'm fine."
"Stop overthinking."
"I just need to be alone."

WHAT THEY MEAN

"I'm overwhelmed and scared."
"I feel like I'm losing myself."
"I'm afraid of getting hurt."
"I'm dysregulated and shutting down."
"I can't handle this conversation yet."
"I need to self-regulate before connecting."

WHAT HELPS AN FA FEEL SAFE ENOUGH TO STAY

1 Predictability Without Pressure

Show up consistently in low-stakes ways. A "good morning" text. Remembering a small detail. This builds felt safety without triggering their intimacy fear.

2 Space That Doesn't Feel Like Rejection

When you give space calmly, without guilt-tripping, their nervous system starts to learn something new: "Space does not mean they are leaving me."

3 Naming Emotions Without Expectation

Saying "I notice I feel disconnected. I'm not asking you to fix it, just sharing" removes the pressure and shows them that it is safe to talk about feelings, something many FAs never learned growing up.

4 Staying Regulated Yourself

Your nervous system is contagious. When you can stay grounded during their withdrawal, it signals safety, not danger. This is the most powerful thing you can offer an FA.



CO-REGULATION RESEARCH

When two people are close, their nervous systems actually affect each other. When you stay calm, it helps calm their body down too. Scientists call this co-regulation. Your peace is genuinely contagious. A calm partner is one of the most healing things an FA can experience.

Porges (2011): Polyvagal Theory; Coan et al. (2006): Partner Regulation fMRI Study

What You Must Stop Doing

These feel like survival. But they're keeping you stuck.



WHAT PROTEST BEHAVIORS ACTUALLY ARE

Researcher John Bowlby called these protest behaviors: automatic things your nervous system does when it senses the connection is slipping. They are not character flaws. But every single one of them sets off the FA's fear alarm and makes them pull further away.

7 PROTEST BEHAVIORS THAT BACKFIRE WITH AN FA

Pulling Up

Multiple texts, calls, showing up. The more silent they go, the louder the protest gets.

Silence = the relationship is ending

Withdrawing Back

Silent treatment, back-turning, phone engrossment. Hoping they notice and come back.

If I pull away first, they can't hurt me

Keeping Score

Timing texts, waiting for them to move first, tracking who owes what

Love should be equal or I always lose

Acting Hostile

Eye-rolling, short answers, rudeness, leaving mid-conversation. Anger as a bid for any response.

Fighting is still contact

Threatening to Leave

Empty "we should break up" statements. Not meant, sent to force proof they want to stay

I need you to choose me out loud

Manipulation

Fake plans, pretending to be busy, ignoring texts. Engineering the pursuit they won't give naturally.

My real needs aren't enough

Making Jealous

Mentioning an ex, hanging out with someone threatening, posting to look wanted. Activating their fear of losing you so you'll finally feel chosen.

If I can make you afraid to lose me, I'll feel wanted

YOUR REGULATION TOOLKIT: USE THESE INSTEAD

1

The 20-Minute Rule

Feel the urge to reach out in a panic? Wait 20 minutes first. Walk, breathe, move your body. Your stress hormone peaks at around 20 minutes and then drops, so you can respond from a calm place instead of from fear.

2

Narrate Your Need, Don't Act It Out

Instead of 5 texts, send one: *"I'm feeling disconnected and wanted to be honest. No pressure on you.."* Naming it is vulnerable. Acting it out is pursuing.

3

Build a Life Outside This Relationship

When they are the main thing keeping you okay, every time they pull away feels like a crisis. Friendships, hobbies, and therapy give your nervous system other places to go, so you are not fully dependent on their behavior.

4

Know Your Breaking Point

Notice your limit. How long of silence before you start to spiral? Knowing your breaking point lets you plan how to calm yourself down before the panic hits, not after.



NERVOUS SYSTEM SCIENCE

Taking a double breath (two short inhales through your nose, then one long slow exhale through your mouth) is the fastest proven way to calm your body's alarm system, even faster than regular deep breathing. Try it before you respond to your partner.

Balban et al. (2023): Stanford; Huberman Lab, Stress & Anxiety Protocols

Communication Scripts That Actually Work

Words that create safety instead of triggering the cycle



HOW TO USE THESE

These scripts are designed to keep the FA's fear alarm from going off while still honestly sharing how you feel. Practice them out loud before you need them. The goal is to stay calm first, and connect second.

WHEN THEY PULL AWAY

TEXT SCRIPT: LOW PRESSURE

"Hey, I notice you've been quiet and I want you to know there's no pressure. I'm here when you're ready."

"I'm not going anywhere. Take the space you need."

"I care about you and I trust us. Talk when you're ready "

WHEN YOU NEED REASSURANCE

IN-PERSON: VULNERABLE, NOT DEMANDING

"I want to share something without making it about you. I'm feeling disconnected and that brings up some old fear in me. I'm working on it. I just wanted you to know."

"I know you sometimes need space. I want to be the kind of partner who can give that gracefully. Can we check in later today?"

WHEN THEY COME BACK AFTER PULLING AWAY

WELCOMING WITHOUT PUNISHING

"I'm really glad you're here. I missed you."

"I'm not going to punish you for needing space. I want us to be able to do that well together."

"Can we talk about what happened? Not to blame anyone. Just so we can do better.."

THE REPAIR CONVERSATION FRAMEWORK

THE 4-PART REPAIR SCRIPT

- 1 Observe (no blame)**
"I noticed when _____ happened..."
- 2 Feel (own your emotion)**
"I felt _____ and that's mine to manage..."
- 3 Need (soft, specific ask)**
"What I need is just a little _____ so I can feel secure..."
- 4 Invite (not demand)**
"Is there anything you're feeling that you'd want to share?"

When This Pairing Can Work, and When to Leave

Honesty is an act of love. Both for them and for yourself.

THIS CAN WORK WHEN...

- Both partners are actively in therapy or doing attachment work
- The FA is self-aware about their patterns and names them
- Both can repair after conflict without weeks of distance
- You are building self-regulation skills independently
- Both partners choose each other consistently, not just in good moments
- The cycle is shortening over time, not lengthening

IT'S TIME TO GO WHEN...

- The FA refuses to acknowledge the cycle or get help
- You feel chronically anxious and it's become your baseline
- The good moments are rare but keep you hooked
- You've abandoned your needs entirely to manage theirs
- There is emotional, verbal, or physical abuse. Full stop.
- You've been in the same loop for years with no growth

RESEARCH FINDING

Research shows that Fearful Avoidants who do EFT (Emotionally Focused Therapy), a type of couples counseling focused on attachment, show real and lasting improvements. The biggest factor is not their attachment style. It is whether they are *willing to do the work*. An FA who wants to grow CAN build a healthy, secure relationship. One who refuses? It is a much harder road.

Johnson & Whiffen (2003): EFT Outcomes Research; Wiebe & Johnson (2016): Follow-up Studies

YOUR AFFIRMATIONS

I deserve a love that doesn't require me to shrink my needs.

Understanding someone's patterns doesn't mean I have to stay in them.

My nervous system deserves peace, not constant activation.

I can love someone deeply and still choose myself.

My healing is not dependent on their willingness to heal.

Secure love exists. And I am becoming ready to receive it.



A FINAL NOTE FROM ASH

This dynamic is not a sign that you chose wrong or that you're broken. It's a sign that your early experiences shaped you, and you found someone whose early experiences shaped them similarly. That recognition, painful as it is, is the beginning of healing. You now have the map. Use it.

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Anxious Attachment

Fearful Avoidant

Attachment Theory

Science-Backed

Check Your Understanding

Mark True or False for each statement, then answer the reflection prompt. Check the answer key when you are done.

TRUE OR FALSE

- 1 A Fearful Avoidant pulls away because they have stopped caring about the relationship. TRUE FALSE
- 2 The FA hot-and-cold pattern is a nervous system response, not a deliberate choice to hurt you. TRUE FALSE
- 3 Fearful Avoidants want deep connection. They just fear it at the same time. TRUE FALSE
- 4 If you give an FA enough patience and love, their avoidant pattern will eventually go away on its own. TRUE FALSE
- 5 The pursue-withdraw cycle intensifies because each person's reaction triggers the other's response. TRUE FALSE
- 6 An FA who is willing to work on themselves can build a secure, lasting relationship. TRUE FALSE

REFLECTION

Before reading this guide, how did you interpret your partner pulling away? Write what you used to think it meant, and what you understand now.

I used to think it meant...

Now I understand it means...

ANSWER KEY

Q1

FALSE

Q2

TRUE

Q3

TRUE

Q4

FALSE

Q5

TRUE

Q6

TRUE

Decode the Protest: Name the Wound

Both partners can do this exercise. Read each scenario, write which protest behavior it is, then name the attachment wound underneath. Check the answer key when you are done.

PART A: SPOT THE BEHAVIOR. WRITE WHICH CATEGORY MATCHES EACH SCENARIO

CATEGORIES: Pulling Up · Withdrawing · Keeping Score · Acting Hostile · Threatening to Leave · Manipulation · Making Jealous

SCENARIO 1

She hasn't heard from him in three hours. She texts once, then again, then calls. When he doesn't answer, she texts "ok I guess I know where we stand" and then three minutes later "actually whatever, I'm fine."

Behavior: _____

SCENARIO 2

He goes quiet during an argument. Instead of engaging, she puts her phone face-down, turns her back, and walks into the other room without a word.

Behavior: _____

SCENARIO 3

She's been waiting two days for him to initiate contact. She's not texting first. She's counting. She's watching his Instagram story views. She's waiting for him to ask first, getting angrier with every hour he doesn't.

Behavior: _____

SCENARIO 4

After two days of distance, she sends "I think maybe we should just take a break. This doesn't seem to be working." She does not want a break. She wants him to say he doesn't want one either.

Behavior: _____

SCENARIO 5

He's not responding. She texts her ex "hey stranger ", posts a photo looking great, and casually mentions in a group chat that she's been "getting a lot of attention lately."

Behavior: _____

PART B: NAME THE WOUND. WRITE THE ATTACHMENT FEAR UNDERNEATH EACH BEHAVIOR

Pulling Up

The wound underneath is:

Threatening to Leave

The wound underneath is:

Making Jealous

The wound underneath is:

ANSWER KEY

S1: Pulling Up / Excessive Contact: escalating contact is the attachment system screaming "please confirm I still exist to you."

S2: Withdrawing: counter-withdrawal protest: "I'll leave before you can."

S3: Keeping Score: tracking contact ratios is how anxious attachment monitors the relationship's safety in real time.

S4: Threatening to Leave: the ultimate test: will you fight for this?

S5: Making Jealous: "if I look wanted, maybe you'll remember you want me." | **Pulling Up wound:** Silence = abandonment. | **Threatening wound:** Fear of not being chosen. | **Jealousy wound:** Fear of being replaceable.

Final Knowledge Check + Your Commitment

Five questions covering the full guide. Then write the one thing you are committing to do differently starting today.

MULTIPLE CHOICE: CIRCLE ONE ANSWER PER QUESTION

1. The pursue-withdraw cycle intensifies because:

- ☐ A. The anxious partner is too needy and drives the FA away
- ☐ B. Each person's nervous system reaction triggers the other's, making both responses stronger
- ☐ C. The FA does not love the anxious partner enough to stay committed

2. The most effective move when an FA goes cold is:

- ☐ A. Go cold yourself to trigger their fear of abandonment
- ☐ B. Send a heartfelt message explaining how their distance is affecting you
- ☐ C. Send one warm, low-pressure message and then give space

3. When an FA pulls away after a close moment, this most likely means:

- ☐ A. The closeness triggered their nervous system and they need to regulate, not a rejection
- ☐ B. They regret getting close and want to end the relationship
- ☐ C. They are testing to see if you will chase them

4. The deciding factor in whether a relationship with an FA can work is:

- ☐ A. How patient and understanding their partner is willing to be
- ☐ B. Whether the FA is willing to look at their patterns and do the work
- ☐ C. How long the two people have known each other

5. The most important thing you can do for your own healing in this dynamic is:

- ☐ A. Understand the FA deeply enough to anticipate and manage their triggers for them
- ☐ B. Build your own self-regulation skills so your peace is not dependent on their responses
- ☐ C. Give the relationship more time. Eventually the pattern resolves itself.

ANSWER KEY

Q1

B

Q2

C

Q3

A

Q4

B

Q5

B

My One Commitment

Write the one specific thing you are committing to do differently starting today.

STARTING TODAY, I WILL STOP:

STARTING TODAY, I WILL TRY:
